A FREE, PLAIN-SPOKEN GUIDE



Protect Your Parents

Keeping Parents and Grandparents Safe from Phone, Text, and Email Scams

Grandkid calls • Fake tech support
Gift cards • Crypto ATMs • Call blocking

D.A. Williams

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Published by Red Pills of Freedom

Free to share. Please pass it on to someone who needs it.

Dedicated to Mom, Janis Fredlund

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This book is for general education. It is not legal or financial advice. Facts and figures were checked against the sources listed in the Notes at the back of the book as of October 2026. Phone settings, websites, and phone numbers change. If something looks different when you try it, check the official website named in the book.

The short scenes marked "Example" in this book are made up to show how a scam usually works. They are not stories about real people.

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INTRODUCTION

The Call That Comes on a Quiet Afternoon

Most scams against older people don't start with anything dramatic. They start with a phone ringing on an ordinary afternoon. Or a text about a package. Or a box that pops up on the computer screen and won't go away.

Then, in a few minutes, a person who has been careful with money for fifty years is standing at a store counter buying gift cards, or feeding cash into a machine at a gas station, or reading bank numbers to a stranger. Not because they are foolish. Because someone very skilled made them afraid, rushed them, and told them not to tell anyone.

The numbers are hard to look at. In 2025, people 60 and older filed more than 201,000 complaints with the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) and reported losing about $7.7 billion.[1] The Federal Trade Commission (FTC) says reported fraud losses by older adults went from about $600 million in 2020 to $2.4 billion in 2024.[2] And most fraud is never reported at all. The FTC

estimates that the true cost of fraud to older adults in 2024 was somewhere between $10.1 billion and $81.5 billion, and it says plainly that this range is very uncertain.[3]

Those are two different reporting systems, with different rules, so please don't add them together. Either way, it is a lot of retirement savings.

Here is something the numbers also show, and it matters: older adults report *losing* money to fraud at a lower rate than younger adults do. The FTC thinks that may mean older people are often better at spotting a scam and hanging up, or more likely to report a scam even when they didn't lose anything.[2] So this is not a book about how older people are helpless. They are not. This is a book about the specific tricks that work, so you can see them coming.

Who this book is for

This book is for two kinds of readers, and they often live in the same family.

If you are an adult child or grandchild, you probably picked this up because you're worried about Mom, Dad, Grandma, or Grandpa. Maybe something already happened. Maybe a friend's parent lost money and you thought, "That could be my dad." This book will show you what the main scams look like, how to set up simple

protections, and how to talk about it without making anyone feel stupid.

If you are an older adult yourself, this book is for you too. You don't need anyone's permission to protect yourself. Every step in here is something you can do on your own, at your own kitchen table.

How this book works

- **Chapter 1** shows the simple pattern behind almost every scam.
- **Chapters 2 through 6** walk through the big ones: the "grandkid in trouble" call, fake tech support, fake government agents, the payment tricks (gift cards, crypto ATMs, cash couriers), and scam texts and emails.
- **Chapter 7** is the hands-on part: blocking calls, setting up a "trusted contact" at the bank, and other protections.
- **Chapter 8** is about how to talk to each other about this.
- **Chapter 9** is what to do if money has already been lost.

At the back, there is a one-page checklist you can print and tape by the phone, a list of free places to get help, and the Notes. Every number and fact in this book comes from a source listed in the Notes, with a web address, so you can check it yourself.

A companion guide in this series, *After a Scam*, goes much deeper into recovery if the worst has already happened.

CHAPTER 1

How Every One of These Scams Works

Scams come in hundreds of costumes. But underneath, almost all of them follow the same simple pattern. The Social Security Administration and its Inspector General describe it with four P's: the scammer will **Pretend**, bring up a **Prize or Problem**, apply **Pressure**, and demand a certain kind of **Payment**.[4]

Once you can see those four pieces, you can spot a scam even if you've never heard that exact story before.

1. Pretend

The caller pretends to be someone you trust. A grandson. A police officer. Someone from your bank's fraud department. A Microsoft or Apple technician. An agent from Social Security, Medicare, the IRS, or even the FTC.

Caller ID won't save you here. Scammers can make any name or number show up on your screen. This is called "spoofing." Social Security warns that scammers spoof official government phone numbers, and even numbers

for local police departments.[5] So if caller ID says "Social Security Administration," that tells you nothing.

2. A prize or a problem

Next comes the hook. Either something wonderful is happening (you won a sweepstakes) or something terrible is happening:

- Your grandson is in jail.
- Your computer has been hacked.
- Your Social Security number has been "suspended" or used in a crime.
- Someone is using your bank account.
- Your Medicare benefits are about to be cut off.

The problem is almost always fake. But it's designed to make your heart pound.

3. Pressure

Then comes the rush. You have to act *now*. Today. Before the bank closes. Before the warrant is issued. Before your grandson spends the night in a cell.

And almost always: **don't tell anyone.** The "grandson" doesn't want his parents to know. The "federal agent" says the bank teller might be part of the crime. The "tech support" person says you'll be in trouble if you hang up.

Scammers need secrecy because the moment you talk to someone you trust, the spell usually breaks. The Social Security Administration lists “demand secrecy” as one of its red flags.[5]

4. Payment

Finally, the scammer tells you exactly how to pay, and it’s always a way that’s hard to trace or take back:

- Gift cards (reading the numbers off the back)
- Cash, sometimes picked up at your door by a “courier”
- A cryptocurrency ATM (sometimes called a Bitcoin ATM)
- A wire transfer
- Gold bars or other precious metals
- A payment app like Zelle, Venmo, or Cash App

The FTC is blunt about gift cards: “No real business or government agency will ever tell you to buy a gift card to pay them.”[6] And Social Security says it will never require payment by gift card, prepaid debit card, wire transfer, internet currency, or mailed cash.[7]

> **THE MOST IMPORTANT THING IN THIS BOOK:** If someone you didn’t expect to hear from tells you to pay with gift cards, cash, crypto, gold, or a wire,

> and to keep it a secret, it is a scam. Every time. Hang up and call someone you trust.

What to do: the “Stop, Hang Up, Call Back” habit

You will never memorize every scam. You don’t need to. You need one habit:

1. **Stop.** Notice the rush. If your heart is pounding, that’s the scam working. The Social Security Administration’s first piece of advice is simply to pause, take a breath, and talk to someone you trust.[5]
2. **Hang up.** You are allowed to hang up on anyone, including someone who says they’re a police officer. Real agencies will survive. You can also just not answer the text or close the email.
3. **Call back on a number you already know.** Use the number on the back of your bank card, on your Social Security or Medicare statement, or in your own contacts list. Never use a number the caller gives you, or a number in the text or pop-up. The FTC gives this same advice again and again.[8]

That’s it. If you or your parent remember nothing else, remember those three steps.

CHAPTER 2

“Grandma, It’s Me. I’m in Trouble.”

This one is called the grandparent scam, or the family emergency scam. It goes straight for the heart.

> *Example (made up to show how it works): The phone rings at 7 a.m. A young man is crying. “Grandma? It’s me. I was in a car accident and they arrested me. Please don’t tell Mom and Dad.” Before she can think, a calm man takes the phone. He says he’s the public defender. Bail is $8,000. It has to be paid today. Someone from the court can come by the house to pick up the cash.*

How it works

The FTC describes it this way: the caller pretends to be a grandchild, says they’re in trouble and need money for bail, a lawyer, a hospital bill, or some other emergency, and begs you to keep it secret. Sometimes a second scammer gets on the phone pretending to be a lawyer or police officer.[9]

A few details make it work:

- **The caller may sound off, and has an excuse.** The FTC notes scammers “might speak softly or make an excuse for why they sound different.”[9]
- **They may know real details.** Scammers sometimes use information from social media, or from a hacked email account, to sound convincing.[10]
- **They may use a cloned voice.** The FTC has warned that scammers can use artificial intelligence (AI) to clone a family member’s voice from a short audio clip posted online.[11] (The third guide in this series, *Is That Really Their Voice?*, covers AI voice cloning in depth.)
- **They may come to the door.** The FTC warned in 2021 that some grandparent scammers now send someone to the house to pick up the cash.[9] That’s frightening, because now a stranger knows where your parent lives.

What to do

1. **Hang up, even if it sounds exactly like them.** The FTC’s advice is simple: “Don’t trust the voice.”[11]
2. **Call the grandchild directly** on the number you already have for them.
3. **If you can’t reach them, call someone else in the family,** “even though the scammer said not to,” as the FTC puts it.[9]

4. **Never hand cash to anyone who comes to the door** for this, and don’t give your address to the caller.
5. **Report it.** If money was lost, it’s a crime: call local police. Report any scam call to the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.[9]

Set this up today: a family code word

Many families now choose a secret word or phrase that only real family members know. If someone calls in a panic, you ask for the word. A real grandchild will know it. A scammer won’t.

The FBI recommends exactly this: create a secret word or phrase with your family to verify their identity.[12]

How to set it up:

- Pick something easy to remember but not findable online. Not a pet’s name, street, or school that’s on Facebook.
- Share it in person or on a call you started, not in a group text or social media post.
- Agree on the rule: “If I’m ever in trouble and calling for money, I’ll say the word. If I can’t, call Mom first.”
- Practice it once, so it isn’t awkward in a real emergency.

What adult children and grandchildren can say

The FTC suggests a few simple lines you can say to an older relative.[13] For example:

- “I’ll never call and ask you to send money for an emergency. That’s a scam. Hang up!”
- “If someone pressures you to secretly send money to get me (or someone you know) out of trouble, that’s a scam. Slow down and check it out.”

Saying it out loud matters. Your parent or grandparent will remember *your* voice saying “I’ll never do that.”

CHAPTER 3

Fake Tech Support and the "Phantom Hacker"

Tech support scams are one of the biggest money-losers for older adults. In 2025, people 60 and older filed 21,333 tech and customer support complaints with the FBI and reported losing more than $1 billion to them.[1] The FTC says older adults are much more likely than younger adults to report losing money to tech support scams.[2]

How it starts

According to the FTC, these scams usually start one of three ways:[14]

- **A pop-up warning** on the computer that looks like it's from Microsoft or Apple, saying there's a virus and to call a number right away. Sometimes it makes loud noises or seems to freeze the screen.
- **A call or text** from someone saying they're a technician from a well-known company.
- **A fake "renewal" email or text** saying you were charged hundreds of dollars for a Geek Squad,

McAfee, or Norton subscription, and to call within 24 hours to cancel.

Once you’re on the phone, the “technician” asks you to download a program that lets them control your computer remotely. Then they pretend to find a problem and ask to be paid to fix it.

The “Phantom Hacker”: when it gets much worse

In 2023, the FBI warned about a bigger version it calls the “Phantom Hacker” scam. It has three acts, each with a different fake character:[15]

1. **The fake tech support person** gets into the computer, “finds” a hacker, and asks you to log into your bank accounts to check for problems. They’re really looking to see where the money is.
2. **The fake bank fraud department** calls next. They say a foreign hacker has gotten into your accounts and you need to move your money to a “safe” account, sometimes said to be at the Federal Reserve or another government agency.
3. **The fake government agent** may call to “confirm” the story, sometimes sending official-looking letters.

The FBI said victims often lose entire bank, savings, retirement, or investment accounts this way. In the first half of 2023 alone, almost half of the tech support victims

who reported to the FBI were over 60, and they accounted for 66% of the losses.[15]

The FTC says these “false alarm” scams are growing fast. From 2020 to 2024, reports from older adults who lost $10,000 or more to fake business and government impersonators went up more than fourfold. Combined losses reported by older adults who lost more than $100,000 went from $55 million to $445 million.[16]

The two facts that stop it cold

The FTC says remembering two things will help you avoid a tech support scam:[14]

1. **Real tech companies won’t contact you** by phone, email, or text to tell you there’s a problem with your computer.
2. **Real security pop-ups never ask you to call a phone number.**

And one more from the FTC: someone who works for the government will never tell you to move your money to “protect it.” There is no such thing as a “federal safety locker.”[14]

What to do

If a scary pop-up appears:

1. Don’t call the number. Don’t click anything in the box.

2. Close the browser. If it won’t close, restart the computer (hold the power button down if you have to).
3. If you’re still worried, run your own security software, or ask someone you know and trust, or a store you choose yourself, to look at it.[14]

If someone already got into the computer:

1. Turn off the internet connection (unplug the cable or turn off Wi-Fi), then shut the computer down.
2. Call your bank and card companies using the numbers on the back of your cards. Tell them what happened.
3. Change your passwords, especially email and banking, from a different device. The FTC says to change any password you gave a scammer, and anywhere else you used the same password.[14]
4. Have the computer checked by someone you trust.
5. Report it at ReportFraud.ftc.gov and ic3.gov.

If money has already been moved: call the bank right now. The FBI says that when you discover a fraudulent transfer, “time is of the essence,” and to file a complaint at ic3.gov with full transaction details, because its Recovery Asset Team can sometimes work with banks to freeze money. In 2025, it helped freeze about $32.9 million of the $65.4 million reported in cases it took on

for victims 60 and older.[1] That’s about half. It is not a guarantee. But speed matters.

CHAPTER 4

Fake Government: Social Security, Medicare, and "Federal Agents"

Scammers love to pretend to be the government, because most of us were raised to take the government seriously. In 2025, people 60 and older reported losing more than $413 million to government impersonation scams to the FBI.[1]

Social Security scams

Here is what the real Social Security Administration (SSA) says it will **never** do:[7]

- Threaten you with arrest or legal action.
- Suspend your Social Security number.
- Demand immediate payment.
- Require payment by cash, gift card, prepaid debit card, internet currency, or wire transfer.
- Ask for gift card numbers over the phone, or ask you to wire or mail cash.

- Ask for personal or bank details to give you a cost-of-living increase.

SSA also says it will never ask for sensitive personal information through social media, email, or text message.[5]

When does Social Security really call? SSA says it generally calls only if you recently applied for a benefit, already get payments and need to update your record, or asked for a call. If there's a problem with your number or record, it will usually mail you a letter.[7]

Some scammers send pictures of badges, credentials, or official-looking documents to seem real, and they may use the real names of government employees, Social Security warns.[5]

Medicare scams

Medicare scams usually go after your Medicare number, which crooks can use to bill for things you never got.

Medicare says it will never call you to sell you anything or visit you at your home. Medicare, or someone representing it, will only call and ask for personal information in limited situations, like returning your call after you joined a plan or left a message.[18]

Medicare's advice:[18]

- Don't give your Medicare card, Medicare number, Social Security card, or Social Security number to anyone except your doctor or people you know should have it, like your insurer or your State Health Insurance Assistance Program (SHIP).
- Don't accept offers of money or gifts for free medical care.
- Don't join a Medicare health or drug plan over the phone unless *you* called and asked for help.
- Compare your Medicare statements with your calendar to make sure you actually got each service listed.

The "your money isn't safe" story

Some of the worst government-impersonation scams claim your Social Security number is being used in a crime like drug smuggling or money laundering, and that you must move your money to keep it safe. The FTC calls this one of the three big lies behind scams that are draining older adults' life savings.[17]

Remember the FTC's rule: no real government employee will ever tell you to move your money to protect it, withdraw cash, or buy gold and hand it to someone.[14]

What to do

1. **Hang up.** Don't argue, don't confirm any information, don't press any buttons.
2. **Check directly.** For Social Security, call 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778) or use your *my* Social Security account at ssa.gov.[19] For Medicare, call 1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227).[18]
3. **Report it.** Report Social Security impersonation to the SSA Office of the Inspector General at oig.ssa.gov/report.[5] Report suspected Medicare fraud to 1-800-MEDICARE or online.[18] Report any government imposter to the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.
4. **If you gave out your Social Security or Medicare number,** see Chapter 9 and go to IdentityTheft.gov.

CHAPTER 5

Gift Cards, Crypto ATMs, and Cash Couriers

Every scam in this book ends the same way: with money leaving your hands in a way that is hard to get back. If you learn to recognize the *payment* request, you can stop almost any scam at the last step, even if you believed the story up to that point.

Gift cards

Here's how the FTC describes it: the scammer tells you which cards to buy (Google Play, Apple, Target, eBay, Amazon) and often which store to go to. They may tell you to buy cards at several stores so cashiers won't get suspicious. They may stay on the phone while you shop. Then they ask for the card number and PIN on the back. Once they have those numbers, the money is gone, even if you still hold the card.[6]

Gift cards are for gifts. Only scammers ask to be paid with them.

If it already happened: keep the card and the receipt. Contact the gift card company right away, no matter how

long ago it happened, and ask for your money back. The FTC says some companies might refund it, so it's worth asking. Then report it at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.[6]

Cryptocurrency ATMs (Bitcoin ATMs)

These machines look like regular ATMs and often sit in convenience stores, gas stations, and grocery stores. But instead of giving you cash, they take your cash and turn it into cryptocurrency.[20]

Scammers love them. A typical story goes like this: there's a problem with your bank account, or your identity is tied to a crime, so you need to withdraw cash and put it into a crypto ATM to "protect" it. The scammer then gives you a QR code (a square barcode) to scan at the machine. As soon as you do, the money goes straight into the scammer's account.[20]

The numbers:

- In the first half of 2024, people 60 and over were more than three times as likely as younger adults to report losing money at a crypto ATM, and they reported about 71% of the money lost this way. The median reported loss was $10,000.[21]
- In 2025, the FBI received 13,460 complaints involving crypto ATMs, with $389 million in losses. People 60 and over filed 6,188 of those complaints and reported about $257 million of the losses.[1]

The FTC's advice: "Don't believe anyone who says you need to use a Bitcoin ATM to protect your money or fix a problem. Real businesses and government agencies will never do that — anyone who does is a scammer." And: never withdraw cash in response to an unexpected call or message.[8]

Cash couriers and gold

In some scams, a "courier," "agent," or "bail officer" comes to the house to pick up cash, gold, or other valuables. Social Security lists meeting you in person to pick up cash, gold bars, or other assets as a red flag of a scam.[5] The FTC warned that grandparent scammers now do this too.[9]

No real government agency, bank, or court sends someone to your home to collect cash or gold.

Wire transfers and payment apps

The FTC says wiring money through companies like MoneyGram, Ria, or Western Union "is like sending cash — once you send it, you usually can't get it back." It also says it's illegal for a telemarketer to ask you to pay by wire.[22] The FTC says scammers ask for payment apps for the same reason: it's like paying with cash, and once you pay, it's hard to get your money back.[14] Treat any stranger's request to "just send it by app" as a red flag.

What to do

1. **Make a family rule:** "We never pay anyone with gift cards, crypto, gold, or cash handed to a stranger. Ever."
2. **If you are about to pay this way because someone called you,** stop and call a family member first.
3. **If money already went out,** act fast. Call the company you paid through right away: - For gift cards: the gift card company (the FTC keeps a contact list on its gift card page).[6] - For wires: MoneyGram 1-800-926-9400, Western Union 1-800-448-1492, or Ria 1-877-443-1399 (for Walmart2Walmart and Walmart2World transfers, Ria's number is 1-855-355-2144). Ask them to reverse the transfer.[22] - For bank transfers: your bank, using the number on your card or statement.
4. **Report it** at ReportFraud.ftc.gov and ic3.gov. For crypto, include the wallet address and transaction details if you have them.

CHAPTER 6

Texts and Emails That Bait the Hook

Not every scam starts with a ring. Many start with a buzz: a text or email that looks like it's from a company you know. In 2025, phishing and spoofing were the most common type of complaint to the FBI from people 60 and older: 48,064 complaints.[1]

What they look like

The FTC lists the kinds of texts scammers send:[2][3]

- A package delivery problem (but the notice is fake).
- "Suspicious activity" on your account.
- A problem with your payment information.
- A fake invoice for something you never bought, with a number to call if you "didn't authorize it."
- A free prize, gift card, or coupon.

Emails look much the same. They often use real logos and copy a real company's look.

The goal is always to get you to click a link, call a number, or reply with personal information. The link

may take you to a fake website that steals your password when you log in.[23]

Simple rules for texts and emails

- **If you weren't expecting it, don't click the link.** The FTC says legitimate companies won't ask for your account information by text.[23]
- **Check it yourself.** If you think it might be real, go to the company's website or app by typing it in yourself, or call a number you know is real.
- **Don't call the number in the message.** That number leads to the scammer.
- **Never give out a code** that was texted to you. Those one-time codes are meant only for you.

What to do

1. **Forward scam texts to 7726** (that spells SPAM). The FTC says this helps your phone company block similar messages.[23]
2. **Use "Report Junk" or "Report Spam"** in your messaging app, then delete it.
3. **Turn on spam filtering** on the phone (see Chapter 7).
4. **If you clicked and typed in a password,** change that password right away from a device you trust, and turn on two-step login if offered. If you typed in bank or card numbers, call the bank.

5. **Report it** at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.

CHAPTER 7

Setting Up Protections, Step by Step

This is the hands-on chapter. You can do most of it in one afternoon at the kitchen table, together. Bring the phone, a list of the bank and credit card numbers, and a cup of coffee.

A gentle reminder for adult children: **do this *with* your parent, not *to* them.** Explain each step. Let them hold the phone. It's their phone and their money.

Step 1: Block and screen calls on the cell phone

The FTC says call blocking and call labeling are your best defense against unwanted calls, because scammers ignore the Do Not Call list.[24] The FCC suggests turning on both the phone's own tools and the phone company's tools.[25]

On an iPhone: Go to Settings, then Apps, then Phone. Apple's current instructions say you can:[26]

- Set **Screen Unknown Callers** to "Ask Reason for Calling" (the phone asks callers not in your contacts

why they're calling before it rings) or to "Silence" (sends them straight to voicemail).

- Under **Call Filtering**, turn on the spam filter.

Important: Before you do this, **add every important number to Contacts**: family, doctors, pharmacy, the bank. Apple recommends this so those calls always come through.[26]

On a Google Pixel or many Android phones: Open the Phone app, tap the menu (More), then Settings, then "Spam and Call Screen" or "Call Screen." Google's Call Screen can answer calls from unknown or suspicious numbers, ask who's calling and why, and show you a live transcript before you decide to pick up.[27] Exact steps vary by phone model and country. Google notes that not every spam call can be detected.

From the phone company: The major carriers offer tools. The FCC lists AT&T ActiveArmor, T-Mobile Scam Shield, and Verizon Call Filter.[25] Some are free, some cost extra. Call the carrier or check its website to ask what's included.

Step 2: Protect the home phone (landline)

If your parent has a home phone:

- **Find out what kind it is.** If phone service comes from the cable or internet company, it's probably an internet phone (called VoIP), and the provider may

offer a free or paid blocking service. The FCC lists Nomorobo as one third-party service for these lines (the FCC doesn't endorse any product).[25]

- **For a traditional landline,** the FTC suggests a call-blocking device, a small box that attaches to the phone and stops calls from known scam numbers, or only lets through numbers you approve.[24]

Step 3: Register on the Do Not Call list (but don't rely on it)

Sign up for free at DoNotCall.gov or call 1-888-382-1222 (TTY 1-866-290-4236) from the phone you want to register. It should cut down on sales calls from real companies that follow the law. It will not stop scammers, who ignore it. The FTC says being on the list does make scam calls easier to spot: if a robocall is trying to sell you something and you never gave written permission, the call is illegal.[24,28]

Step 4: Name a "trusted contact" at the bank and brokerage

This is one of the most useful protections, and most people have never heard of it.

A **trusted contact person** is someone your parent chooses (like an adult child, a friend, or an attorney) whom the bank or brokerage firm may call if it can't reach your parent or if it suspects fraud or exploitation.

At a brokerage (investment) firm: Under industry rules, firms must ask customers for a trusted contact. A trusted contact must be 18 or older. Naming one *does not* give that person any power to see balances, make trades, or make decisions. It is simply someone the firm can call.[29]

At a bank or credit union: In December 2024, federal bank regulators, including the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB), encouraged banks to let customers name trusted contacts. They said a trusted contact typically would not have authority to view account information or make transactions unless the customer separately authorizes it.[30] Not every bank offers this yet. Ask.

How to do it:

1. Call the bank or brokerage using the number on the statement or card, or go in person.
2. Say: “I’d like to add a trusted contact person to my account.”
3. Give the name and phone number of the person chosen.
4. Write down who was named, at which institution, and the date.

Step 5: Turn on account alerts

Most banks and card companies offer free text or email alerts for large withdrawals, transfers, and purchases. Set a low threshold, like $100. If your parent wants, alerts can also go to a second person, but only with your parent's clear agreement.

Step 6: Consider a free credit freeze

A credit freeze stops anyone, including a scammer, from opening new credit in your name. According to the FTC, it is free to place and lift, it lasts until you lift it, and it doesn't affect your credit score. You have to contact all three credit bureaus: Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion. You can lift it temporarily when you need to apply for credit.[31]

For many retirees who rarely open new credit cards or loans, a freeze is an easy, free layer of protection.

Step 7: Check Medicare statements

If your parent has Original Medicare, they can set up a secure account at Medicare.gov to view claims as soon as they're processed, or go through the paper statements each time they arrive. Look for any service, equipment, or test that you didn't get.[18]

Step 8: Tidy up social media

Scammers use public posts to make their stories believable: names of grandkids, where someone is traveling, the family dog. The FTC suggests checking privacy settings and limiting what you share publicly.[9]

Step 9: Put the plan on paper

Print the checklist at the back of this book. Write on it:

- The family code word (or a hint only you'll understand).
- The names and numbers of two people to call before ever sending money.
- The real numbers for the bank, Social Security, and Medicare.

Tape it next to the phone or on the fridge.

CHAPTER 8

How to Talk About It Without a Fight

You can set up every blocker in the world, but the most powerful protection is a conversation. Scammers depend on secrecy and shame. A family that talks openly about scams takes both away.

For adult children and grandchildren

Make it about the scammers, not about your parent. Nobody likes being told they're getting old or gullible. And it isn't true that only careless people get scammed. These are professional criminals with scripts and call centers. The FBI's 2025 report describes illegal call centers that defraud thousands of victims each year.[1]

Some ways to open the conversation:

- **Share something you read.** "I read that scammers are now cloning people's voices with AI. That's scary. Can we set up a family code word?"
- **Make it about you.** "I almost clicked a fake delivery text last week. These are getting good. Can I show you what I've learned?"

- **Use "we."** "Let's both turn on spam blocking on our phones."
- **Ask for their help.** "Would you help me understand how your bank's fraud alerts work?"

Things to avoid:

- Lecturing, or saying "How could you fall for that?"
- Taking over their accounts or phone without asking.
- Making them promise to "never answer the phone." It won't stick, and they may stop telling you things.

Keep it going. One talk isn't enough. Mention a new scam you saw in the news now and then. The FTC encourages people to "pass it on" to friends and family, because chances are you know someone who will get one of these calls.[10]

For older adults: talking to your kids

If you're reading this for yourself, here are a few things that may help:

- **Tell your family when you get a scam call,** even if you hung up. It helps them, too, and keeps the door open.
- **Choose your "two-call people."** Pick two people you'll always call before sending money to anyone. Tell them they're your two-call people.

- **You can say no to your own family, too.** Protecting your independence matters. Accept the help that makes you feel safer and say no to anything that doesn't feel right. A trusted contact, for example, gets no power over your money.[29]

If you think a parent is being scammed right now

Some signs your parent may be caught up in a scam (these are general warning signs, not proof):

- Secret phone calls, or nervousness when the phone rings.
- Large or unusual withdrawals, or trips to buy gift cards.
- A new "friend," "agent," or "advisor" they won't talk about.
- Talk of moving money to keep it "safe," or of a prize they have to pay fees for.
- New money problems they can't explain.

What to do:

1. **Stay calm and curious.** Ask gentle questions: "Who was that on the phone? What did they want?"
2. **Don't argue about whether it's real.** Scammers often warn their targets that family won't understand. Instead, suggest one simple check together, like calling the bank on the number on the card.

3. **Call the AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline** at 877-908-3360 for free guidance on what to do next.[32]
4. **For people 60 and older,** the U.S. Department of Justice's National Elder Fraud Hotline (1-833-FRAUD-11, or 1-833-372-8311) can help.[33]
5. **If you suspect someone is being financially exploited** by a person close to them, contact Adult Protective Services in their state. The Department of Justice can help you find the right office.[33]
6. **If anyone is in danger, call 911.**

CHAPTER 9

If Something Already Happened

If money or personal information has already gone to a scammer, please hear this first: **it is not a sign of foolishness, and it is not too late to act.** Many people never report a scam because they're embarrassed. Reporting helps you and helps stop the next one.

The second guide in this series, *After a Scam*, covers recovery in detail. Here is the short version.

The first hour

1. **Stop all contact** with the scammer. Don't answer more calls or texts from them.
2. **Call the bank, card company, or payment service** using the number on your card or statement. Tell them it was fraud. Ask them to stop or reverse the payment and to secure the account.
3. **If it was a wire,** call the wire company (numbers in Chapter 5) or your bank and ask them to reverse it.[22]
4. **If it was a gift card,** call the gift card company with the card and receipt.[6]

5. **If someone had remote access to the computer,** disconnect it from the internet and change passwords from another device.[14]

The first day

1. **Report to the FBI at ic3.gov** with every transaction detail you have. The FBI says to report no matter how much was lost.[1]
2. **Report to the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.**
3. **File a police report** if money was lost. The FTC notes it was a crime.[9]
4. **If a Social Security number was shared,** go to IdentityTheft.gov for a step-by-step recovery plan, and consider a credit freeze.[31]

Watch out for the second scam

After people lose money, they often get calls from someone who promises to get it back, for a fee. That's another scam. The FTC warns that refund and recovery scammers target people who already lost money, and that you should never pay upfront for a promise to recover money.[34] The FBI says recovery scams cost people 60 and older about $540 million in 2025 (that figure may include money from the earlier scams that led to the recovery contact).[1]

Take care of the person, not just the money

Losing money to a scam can bring shame, anger, and grief. Be gentle with yourself, or with your parent. AARP runs free, confidential online support groups for fraud victims and their families.[35] If anyone is feeling hopeless, call or text 988, the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, any time.[36]

APPENDIX

The One-Page Family Scam Checklist

Print this page and keep it by the phone. Free to copy and share.

THE NUMBER ONE RULE: If someone you didn't expect tells you to pay with gift cards, cash, crypto, gold, or a wire, and to keep it secret, it's a scam. Hang up.

Red flags. Any one of these means stop and check.

- ☐ They say a loved one is in trouble and needs money now.
- ☐ They say "Don't tell anyone."
- ☐ They say your computer, bank account, or SSN has a problem.
- ☐ A pop-up says to call a number.
- ☐ They want remote access to your computer.
- ☐ They say to move money to "keep it safe."
- ☐ They want gift cards, crypto, gold, wire, or cash.
- ☐ Someone offers to come pick up money.
- ☐ They threaten arrest or loss of benefits.
- ☐ A text asks you to click a link or "verify."
- ☐ You won a prize but must pay first.
- ☐ Caller ID says "government" or "bank" (it can be faked).

Stop. Hang up. Call back on a number you already know.

Our family code word hint: _____

My two-call people (call before sending money):

1. Name: _____ Phone: _____
2. Name: _____ Phone: _____

Real numbers: My bank: _____ · Social Security **1-800-772-1213** · Medicare **1-800-633-4227**

Protections done: ☐ Spam filter on · ☐ Contacts saved · ☐ Do Not Call · ☐ Trusted contact · ☐ Account alerts · ☐ Credit freeze

If money went out: Call the bank or payment company now. Report at **ic3.gov** and **ReportFraud.ftc.gov**. Never pay anyone who promises to get it back.

Help: AARP Fraud Watch **877-908-3360** · Elder Fraud Hotline **1-833-372-8311** · Crisis: **call or text 988**

From Protect Your Parents *by D.A. Williams. Sources are in the book's Notes.*

RESOURCES

Where to Get Help

All of these were checked in October 2026. Phone numbers and hours can change. If something doesn't work, look up the organization's official website yourself. Never use a "help" number that a stranger gives you.

This book is not legal advice. For legal help, contact a lawyer or your local legal aid office.

To report a scam

- **FTC:** ReportFraud.ftc.gov, or 1-877-FTC-HELP (1-877-382-4357).[10]
- **FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center:** ic3.gov.[1]
- **Social Security impersonation:** oig.ssa.gov/report.[5]
- **Medicare fraud:** 1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227).[18]
- **Unwanted calls (no money lost):** DoNotCall.gov.[24]
- **Scam texts:** forward to 7726 (SPAM).[23]
- **Your local police department.**

Free help by phone

- **AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline:** 877-908-3360, Monday–Friday, 8 a.m.–8 p.m. Eastern. Free guidance and support; it does not investigate or recover money.[32]
- **National Elder Fraud Hotline (U.S. Department of Justice):** 1-833-FRAUD-11 (1-833-372-8311).[33]
- **FINRA Securities Helpline for Seniors:** 844-574-3577, Monday–Friday, 9 a.m.–5 p.m. Eastern, for questions about investment accounts.[29]
- **Eldercare Locator:** 1-800-677-1116, to find local aging services.[33]
- **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline:** call or text 988.[36]
- **Emergency:** 911.

Official contacts to keep handy

- **Social Security:** 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778), ssa.gov.[19]
- **Medicare:** 1-800-633-4227, Medicare.gov.[18]
- **Credit freezes:** contact Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion. The FTC explains how at consumer.ftc.gov (search “credit freeze”).[31]
- **Identity theft recovery:** IdentityTheft.gov.

Learn more

- **FTC Pass It On** (materials for older adults and families): ftc.gov/PassItOn.[13]
- **FCC call blocking guides:** fcc.gov/call-blocking.[25]
- **Social Security scam page:** ssa.gov/scam.[5]
- **AARP Fraud Victim Support Group:** search "Fraud Victim Support Group" at aarp.org.[35]

Companion guides in this series

After a Scam, *Is That Really Their Voice?*, *Apps That Actually Help*, *Stop Before You Pay*, *When Banks Cheat You*, *Naked Short Selling*, *Disability Benefits Made Simple*, and *Don't Get Doxxed*, all by D.A. Williams and free to share.

Notes

Web addresses were checked in October 2026. Where a source is a report from a government agency, the figures are based on what people reported to that agency; most scams are never reported, so the real numbers are likely higher, as the agencies themselves note. FBI and FTC figures come from different reporting systems and should not be added together.

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